

Jinnah Postgraduate Medical Centre (JPMC)
Rafiqi Shaheed Road, Karachi
Email: jpmc.edu.pk

INFORMED CONSENT FORM

Project Information

Field	Information
Project Title:	Assessing Cancer Caregiver burden in Karachi's Public Healthcare System.
IRB Ref No:	[To be assigned by JPMC IRB]
Sponsor:	None
Principal Investigator:	Dr. Anita Vallacha
Organization:	Oncology Department, Jinnah Postgraduate Medical Centre (JPMC), Karachi
Phone:	0336-8025062
Other Investigators:	Prof. Dr. Ghulam Haider
Organization:	Oncology Department, Jinnah Postgraduate Medical Centre (JPMC), Karachi
Phone:	0300-2307257

Please read this consent form carefully before deciding whether to participate in this research study.

1. PURPOSE OF THIS RESEARCH STUDY

You are being asked to participate in a research study designed to understand the experiences and challenges faced by family members who care for cancer patients. Many family caregivers in Pakistan experience significant stress, financial difficulties, and emotional strain while caring for their loved ones with cancer. This study aims to measure how burdened caregivers feel and to identify factors that may contribute to higher burden. The information gathered will help healthcare providers develop better support services for caregivers in the future.

2. PROCEDURES

If you agree to participate in this study, you will be asked to do the following:

- Participate in a **face-to-face interview** that will take approximately **20–30 minutes**.
- Answer questions about your experiences as a caregiver using a standard questionnaire called the **Zarit Burden Interview (ZBI-22)**. This questionnaire contains 22 statements about how you may feel while caring for your relative.
- Provide some basic information about yourself (such as age, gender, education, employment, income) and about the patient you care for (such as cancer type, stage, and treatment phase).
- The interview will be conducted in a **private room** at the Oncology Department of JPMC.
- Your participation in this study will be for a **single session only**; there will be no follow-up visits or additional requirements after this interview.

All procedures in this study are for research purposes only. There are no experimental or investigational procedures involved.

3. POSSIBLE RISKS OR DISCOMFORT

This study involves minimal risk. However, there are some potential risks or discomforts that you should be aware of:

Psychological/Emotional Risks

- Some questions may ask about your feelings of stress, anger, worry, or financial difficulty while caring for your relative. These topics may be sensitive or upsetting for some people.
- You may feel tired or emotionally drained after discussing your caregiving experiences.

Time and Inconvenience

- The interview will take approximately 20–30 minutes of your time.

Steps to Minimize Risks

- The interview will be conducted in a private, comfortable setting to ensure your privacy.
- You are free to **skip any question** you do not wish to answer.

- You may **take a break** at any time during the interview.
- You may **withdraw from the study at any time** without any penalty or effect on your or your family member's medical care.
- If you experience significant emotional distress, you will be offered referral to psychosocial support services within JPMC.
- The interviewer has been trained to be sensitive and respectful throughout the process.

Note: If any new information becomes available during the study that may affect your willingness to continue participation, you will be informed immediately.

4. POSSIBLE BENEFITS

Direct Benefits to You

- This study may not provide any direct medical or financial benefit to you personally.
- However, you may find it helpful to have the opportunity to talk about your caregiving experiences and feel heard.

Benefits to Others

- The information collected will help healthcare providers and policymakers understand the challenges faced by caregivers like you.
- This knowledge will be used to develop better support services, counseling programs, and interventions for caregivers of cancer patients in Pakistan.
- Your participation may help improve the well-being of future caregivers and their patients.

5. FINANCIAL CONSIDERATIONS

- **There is no financial compensation** (payment) for participation in this research study.
- There are **no additional costs** to you for participating in this study.
- You will not be charged for the interview or any study-related procedures.
- If you are referred to psychosocial support services, these will be provided through existing JPMC services at no additional cost to you.

6. AVAILABLE TREATMENT ALTERNATIVES

This study does not involve any treatment, experimental or conventional. It is purely a research study involving a questionnaire interview. Your decision to participate or not will not affect the medical care or treatment that you or your family member receives at JPMC.

7. AVAILABLE MEDICAL TREATMENT FOR ADVERSE EXPERIENCES

This study involves **minimal risk**. However, if you experience significant emotional distress as a direct result of taking part in this research study:

- You will be offered a break or the option to stop the interview immediately.
- You may be referred to the psychosocial support or counseling services available at JPMC.
- The cost of any such counseling or support will be covered by JPMC as part of its existing services; you will not be charged.

In case of a research-related emergency, you may contact:

Contact	Information
Principal Investigator	Dr. Anita Vallacha (0336-8025062)

8. CONFIDENTIALITY

Your identity in this study will be treated as strictly confidential. The following steps will be taken to protect your privacy:

- Your name will not be recorded on any data collection forms. Instead, you will be assigned a unique participant code number.
- All paper records (consent forms, questionnaires) will be stored in a locked cabinet accessible only to the research team.
- Electronic data will be stored on password-protected computers with encrypted files.
- Only the research team will have access to any data that could identify you.
- The results of the study may be published for scientific purposes, but your name or any identifiable information will never be included.
- However, any records or data obtained as a result of your participation in this study may be inspected by authorized representatives of the JPMC Institutional Review Board (IRB) for audit and quality assurance purposes. These individuals are bound by confidentiality obligations.

9. RIGHTS TO PARTICIPATE, SAY NO, OR WITHDRAW

1. **Participation in this research project is completely voluntary.**
2. **You have the right to say no.** You may choose not to participate for any reason, and there will be no penalty or loss of benefits to which you are otherwise entitled.

3. **You may change your mind at any time and can withdraw** from the study without any consequences.
4. **Your decision will not affect** the medical care or treatment you or your family member receive at JPMC.
5. If you decide to withdraw, any data already collected from you will not be used and will be destroyed.

10. TERMINATION OF RESEARCH STUDY

- You are free to choose whether or not to participate or withdraw from this study. There will be **no penalty or loss of benefits** to which you are otherwise entitled if you choose not to participate.
- You will be provided with any significant new findings developed during the course of this study that may relate to or influence your willingness to continue participation.
- In the event you decide to discontinue your participation in the study:
 - **a)** There are no potential consequences for you; your withdrawal will be accepted without question.
 - **b)** Please notify the Principal Investigator (contact information below) of your decision, or simply inform the interviewer that you wish to stop.
- Your participation in the study may be terminated by the investigator without your consent under the following circumstances:
 - If you are unable to continue for any health-related reason.
 - If it becomes apparent that the study is causing you significant distress.
 - If the study is terminated by the IRB or for administrative reasons.

11. AVAILABLE SOURCES OF INFORMATION

a) For questions about this study:

If you have any further questions about this study, please contact the Principal Investigator:

Name:	Dr. Anita Vallacha
Phone:	0336-8025062
Location:	Oncology Department, JPMC, Karachi

b) For questions about your rights as a research participant:

If you have any questions about your rights as a research subject, or if you have concerns or complaints, please contact:

Name:	JPMC Institutional Review Board (IRB) Secretariat
Phone:	021-99205185 (Ask for IRB Office)
Email:	jpmc.edu.pk
Location:	Research Department, Jinnah Postgraduate Medical Centre, Rafiqui Shaheed Road, Karachi

c) In case of a research-related emergency:

Day Emergency Number:	021-99205185 (JPMC Main Line)
Contact Person:	Oncology Department Staff

12. AUTHORIZATION

I have read and understand this consent form, and I volunteer to participate in this research study.

I understand that I will receive a copy of this form for my records.

I voluntarily choose to participate, but I understand that my consent does not take away any legal rights in the case of negligence or other legal fault of anyone who is involved in this study.

Name of Participant:	{{ParticipantName}}
Date:	{{Date}}
Signature of Participant:	{{SignatureField}}

(If the participant is unable to read, an impartial witness must be present during the entire consent process. The witness signs below.)

WITNESS (If applicable):

Name of Witness:	_____
Signature of Witness:	_____
Date:	___ / ___ / 202___

Signature of Person Obtaining Consent:	_____
Name	_____
Date:	___ / ___ / 202___

Signature of Principal Investigator:	Dr. Anita Vallacha
Date:	___ / ___ / 202___

FOR ILLITERATE PARTICIPANTS (IMPARTIAL WITNESS PROCEDURE)

If the participant is unable to read this consent form, the following procedure will be followed:

1. The consent form will be **read aloud and explained** to the participant in their preferred language (Urdu, Sindhi, or English) by the interviewer or a trained translator.
2. An **impartial witness** (not affiliated with the research team) will be present during the entire consent process.
3. The participant will be given the opportunity to ask questions and will be encouraged to ask for clarification.

4. If the participant agrees to participate, their **verbal consent** will be documented, and the witness will sign this form confirming that the information was accurately explained and that the participant voluntarily agreed.

Thank you for considering participation in this important research study. Your contribution will help improve care for cancer patients and their families in Pakistan.